



ASL 101: Classroom Communication and Fingerspelling — A Full Practice Session

ASL 101 • American Sign Language

COURSE-OBJ.ASL101.2

Use beginner ASL etiquette and vocabulary accurately to get attention respectfully, fingerspell names, and ask and answer yes/no and WH-questions with correct facial grammar. A complete 90-minute session packet with warm-up, guided practice, partner/lab work, independent practice, extension work, assessment, and a full answer key.

PRINT • TEACH • REVISIT



Plan the session

Course and objective

ASL 101 · American Sign Language; COURSE-OBJ.ASL101.2 — Apply visual-attention etiquette, fingerspell names and unfamiliar terms at a readable pace, and produce beginner greetings and questions with the correct nonmanual signals.

What is included

Cover; instructor guide; key-term and concept preview; original reading or worked examples; warm-up (2 items); guided practice with organizer (4 items); partner/lab discussion (3 items); independent practice (6 items); small-group extension work (4 items); assessment; complete answer key; access and sources page.

Suggested pacing (90-minute session)

Warm-up 8 min · guided reading of both passages + vocabulary 18 min · guided etiquette/grammar organizer 18 min · partner practice of described exchanges 18 min · independent practice 18 min · extension work 6 min · assessment 4 min.

Preparation

Print student pages separately from the answer key, or distribute through a secure LMS. Review the reading/examples and organizer before class. No paid textbook or app is required.

Student directions

Read or work through the material carefully. Support every answer with evidence, work shown, or clear reasoning.



Before you begin

Key terms

eye gaze — visual contact that holds a turn and carries grammar

fingerspelling — spelling a word with the manual alphabet

nonmanual signal (NMS) — facial/head grammar, e.g. raised eyebrows

sign space — the area used to produce and reference signs

gloss — ALL CAPS notation for signs; not ASL itself

WH- vs. YES/NO marker — furrowed brow (WH-) vs. raised brow (yes/no)

Concept focus

ASL is a full, independent visual-gestural language with its own grammar, not a signed version of English. Meaning comes from handshape, movement, and location together with nonmanual signals (NMS) — facial expressions and head/body posture that function as grammar, not just emotion. A yes/no question is marked by raised eyebrows and a forward head tilt; a WH-question (who, what, where, when, why, how) is marked by furrowed/lowered eyebrows. Fingerspelling is used mainly for names, places, or terms with no established sign, and should flow smoothly rather than being punched out letter by letter. Every exchange depends on shared eye gaze, so getting someone's attention respectfully — a light tap, a wave in their sightline, or a light flick with permission — replaces calling out a name.

Model 1 — Getting attention respectfully

Never grab an arm or wave wildly. Instead: wave once in the person's peripheral vision, tap the shoulder lightly once, or flick the room light with permission — then wait for full eye contact before beginning.

Model 2 — Marking a yes/no question vs. a WH-question

"Are you a student?" uses raised eyebrows and a forward tilt. "Where do you study?" uses lowered, furrowed eyebrows instead. The handshapes stay the same; only the nonmanual signal marks the question type.

WARM-UP

Warm-up

Answer using what you already know or recall from the previous session.

1. What two attention-getting methods does the lesson approve of, and which does it explicitly reject?

2. Why does the lesson say a signer should avoid sitting with a bright window directly behind them?



Before You Sign: Setting Up a Respectful Exchange

Good ASL communication starts before the first sign. A signer chooses a position with clear sightlines: no bright window or lamp directly behind them, since strong backlighting turns hands and face into a dark silhouette that is hard to read. Seating in a small circle or a loose semicircle, rather than in rows, lets every participant see every other participant's hands and face at once — in a spoken classroom, facing forward is normal; in a signing classroom, facing forward can mean facing away from half the conversation.

Attention-getting is a visible, deliberate step, not an interruption to apologize for. A signer who wants to begin a conversation checks whether the other person's eyes are already free. If not, they wait for a natural break, then use one clear, controlled method: a single wave inside the other person's peripheral vision, a light single tap on the shoulder or table near the person, or, in a full classroom, the instructor briefly flicking the light switch. Grabbing an arm, waving repeatedly and rapidly, or shouting a name are all considered intrusive — they treat a Deaf or signing space as if it worked like a hearing one.

Once eye contact is established, it is held for the length of the exchange, not just the greeting. Looking away mid-sentence in ASL is closer to trailing off mid-word in speech: it can signal the turn is being given up. A signer who needs to glance away briefly — to check a phone, for example — should complete their sentence, break eye contact clearly, and then re-establish it before continuing, so their conversation partner is not left guessing whether the exchange is still active.



A Beginner Classroom Exchange, Described

Jamal turns to face Priya directly, positioning himself so the classroom window is behind him rather than behind her, keeping his hands and face clearly lit for her. He waits until her eyes are already on him — she has just finished writing something down and looks up — before he moves. He gives a single, controlled wave at chest height inside her sightline. Priya's eyes come to him immediately and stay there.

Jamal signs a standard greeting, then brings both hands up to fingerspell his name: J-A-M-A-L, produced smoothly, each handshape flowing into the next at a steady, readable rhythm rather than being punched out letter by letter. He follows it with the sign for NAME and a questioning point back toward Priya, his eyebrows raised and his head tilted slightly forward — the nonmanual marker that turns the gesture into a yes/no-style prompt: "And you?"

Priya fingerspells P-R-I-Y-A at a matching pace, then signs STUDENT and points to herself. She lowers and furrows her eyebrows as she signs WHERE, tilting forward — the WH-question marker — asking Jamal where he studies. He answers, naming his program, then mirrors the question back to her with the same WH-question expression. Neither of them looks away mid-question; the eye contact and the facial grammar carry as much of the exchange as the handshapes do.

At the end, Jamal signs THANK-YOU and a closing sign, breaking eye contact only after Priya has clearly signed a closing response back — a visible, mutual signal that the exchange, not just the sentence, is finished.

Partner / lab discussion

Discuss each item with a partner or lab group before writing a joint response.

1. Discuss with a partner: why might looking away mid-sentence in ASL cause confusion, based on the passage's comparison to speech?

2. With a partner, practice the attention-getting sequence described (wait for a break, use one clear method, wait for eye contact) and explain out loud why each step matters.

3. Discuss: why does the lesson recommend a semicircle seating arrangement instead of rows for a signing classroom?



Independent practice

Work independently. Show your work or cite evidence in every answer.

1. How does Jamal fingerspell his name, according to the passage, and what is the recommended rhythm for fingerspelling in general?

2. What is fingerspelling mainly used for, according to the lesson?

3. What does the passage say happens if a signer needs to glance away mid-conversation (for example, to check a phone)?



Independent practice

Work independently. Show your work or cite evidence in every answer.

4. What visible, mutual signal ends the exchange between Jamal and Priya, according to the passage?

5. Explain what "gloss" is and why the lesson calls it "not ASL itself."

6. Write a short plan (3-4 steps) for how you would respectfully get a classmate's attention across a room, using the etiquette described in the lesson.



Small-group extension work

Use for review or additional application practice.

1. A beginner fingerspells a name by pausing heavily between every letter. Using the lesson's guidance, explain what to correct and why.

2. Explain why eye gaze is described as carrying "as much of the exchange as the handshapes do." What would be lost if eye contact broke during a question?



Small-group extension work

Use for learners ready for additional challenge or synthesis.

1. Compare the classroom-seating reasoning in this lesson to a hearing classroom you have experienced. What is one accommodation a hearing classroom would need to add to be signing-friendly?

2. Write a short original description (4-6 sentences, in the same descriptive style as the passage) of a beginner signer asking a classmate a WH-question and receiving an answer, correctly noting the nonmanual signal used.

Assessment

Complete independently to show what you learned today.

1. Self-assessment: describe one specific etiquette or grammar point from today's lesson you feel confident about, and one you still need to practice.



Assessment · self-assessment

Rate today's work:

4 — I can teach this to someone else.

3 — I can do this independently.

2 — I can do this with help.

1 — I need to revisit this before the next session.



Answer key

1. Approved: a single controlled wave in the other person's sightline, or a light single tap on the shoulder (or, in a group, a brief light flick with permission). Rejected: grabbing an arm, waving repeatedly/wildly, or shouting a name.
2. Strong backlighting turns the signer's hands and face into a dark silhouette, making handshape, movement, and facial grammar hard for the other person to read.
3. He positions himself so the window light is behind him, not behind Priya, keeping his own hands and face well-lit for her to read — and he waits for her eyes before beginning.
4. Raised eyebrows with a forward head tilt, marking it as a yes/no-style question.
5. Lowered/furrowed eyebrows with a forward head tilt — the WH-question marker — which differs from the raised-eyebrow yes/no marker used earlier.

Accept equivalent, well-supported alternative answers throughout.



Answer key

6. ASL is described as a full, independent visual-gestural language with its own grammar; meaning comes from handshape, movement, location, and nonmanual signals together, not from mapping English words one-to-one onto signs.
7. The passage compares it to trailing off mid-word — looking away mid-sentence can signal the turn is being given up, so a partner may not know whether the conversation is still active, causing an awkward or confusing pause.
8. Answers vary; must correctly sequence: wait for a natural break, use a single controlled attention-getter, then wait for full eye contact before beginning to sign.
9. Rows work for a spoken classroom where facing forward is enough, but in a signing classroom facing forward can mean facing away from other participants; a semicircle lets everyone see everyone else's hands and face at once.
10. He fingerspells J-A-M-A-L smoothly, each handshape flowing into the next at a steady, readable rhythm — not punched out letter by letter.

Accept equivalent, well-supported alternative answers throughout.



Answer key

11. Proper names, places, or terms that have no established sign.
12. They should complete their sentence, break eye contact clearly, and then re-establish it before continuing, so their partner is not left guessing whether the exchange is still active.
13. Jamal signs THANK-YOU and a closing sign, and only breaks eye contact after Priya has clearly signed a closing response back.
14. Gloss is a limited written notation (ALL CAPS English words) used to discuss or record signs on paper; it is not ASL itself because it cannot capture handshape, movement, location, or nonmanual grammar — it is only a reference tool.
15. Answers vary; must include waiting for a natural break, choosing one non-intrusive method appropriate to the distance (e.g., moving into sightline and waving once, or asking someone closer to relay), and waiting for eye contact before beginning.

Accept equivalent, well-supported alternative answers throughout.



Answer key

16. The lesson recommends a smooth, steady, readable rhythm with letters flowing into each other; heavy pauses between every letter make the word harder to read as a whole rather than easier, and go against the described best practice.

17. Because nonmanual signals (like eyebrow position) are produced with the face while eye gaze maintains the visual channel itself; breaking eye contact could mean missing the nonmanual grammar that distinguishes a yes/no question from a WH-question, or signal that the turn has ended.

18. Answers vary; must identify a specific accommodation (e.g., semicircular seating, controlled/non-backlit lighting, sightline-clear sightlines to an interpreter or the instructor) and connect it to a specific point made in the lesson.

19. Answers vary; must describe a WH-question with the correct nonmanual signal (furrowed/lowered eyebrows, forward head tilt) named explicitly, distinct from a yes/no question.

20. Answers vary; must name a specific point from the lesson (e.g., attention-getting method, fingerspelling rhythm, yes/no vs. WH-question marker) for each part.

Accept equivalent, well-supported alternative answers throughout.



Access, sources, and license

Extension

Ask for a second method, a counterexample, or a short student-led extension of the concept, with a brief explanation of the choice.

Accommodated seating/504

Follow the individual accommodation plan: extended time, breaks, enlarged print, reduced copying, or an alternate response method as documented.

Additional support

Pre-teach key vocabulary or notation before class. Model the first guided item aloud. Accept oral or dictated responses when appropriate.

Multilingual learners

Preview key terms with examples. Allow brief first-language discussion before independent writing. Provide sentence or solution starters.

Course-level alignment · accessed September 18, 2026

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Course-level learning objective written for this packet; no accreditation, transfer credit, or universal course-equivalency is claimed.

Original reading(s)/worked examples, questions, and answer explanations. No textbook or copyrighted course material reproduced.

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